



EVERYONE'S FEAR TAKES ON A LIFE OF ITS OWN

RINGU / 1998

IN CONTEXT

GENRE
Horror

DIRECTOR
Hideo Nakata

WRITER
Hiroshi Takahashi
(screenplay); **Kôji Suzuki**
(novel)

STARS
Nanako Matsushima,
Hiroyuki Sanada, Rikiya
Ôtaka, Yôichi Numata,
Miki Nakatani

BEFORE
1996 *Don't Look Up*, Nakata's first feature, is not a box-office hit but gives him the critical prestige to direct *Ringu*.

AFTER
1999 Nakata completes the story with *Ringu 2*.

2002 Nakata directs *Dark Water*, which, like his previous two movies, is remade by Hollywood.

As with many Western horrors—*Poltergeist* (1982) and *The Blair Witch Project* (1999), for example—Hideo Nakata's movie *Ringu* (*The Ring*) draws its shivers from folklore and legend: in this case an old samurai tale transferred to modern-day urban Japan. The movie is based on Kôji Suzuki's hit 1991 novel of the same name, which in turn was inspired by a well-known 18th-century ghost story about a serving girl, Okiku, who is murdered by her lord.

Taking a key element from US horror movies in which teenagers are drawn to objects or places that are taboo or forbidden, *Ringu* concerns a videotape that is being passed around provincial schools. The



Nakata's movie inspired a new genre of Japanese chillers, several of which were remade by Hollywood. In these "J-horror" movies, the terror is less explicit, with less reliance on "jump scares" and more left to the imagination.

tape lasts just a few seconds and contains strange imagery

of a circle of light, a woman brushing her hair, a man with his head covered, a pictogram seen in a close-up of an eye—all played in the static crackle of a degraded, much-watched video. After each viewing of the tape, the viewer receives a phone call saying they will die in seven days. A week later they are dead, their faces twisted by some unimaginable terror.

“It's not of this world. It's Sadako's fury. And she's put a curse on us.”

Ryuji Takayama / *Ringu*